

The Honest Compound Checklist

Safe vs. Sketchy Compounded GLP-1: The 14 Questions to Ask Before You Inject Anything

The Honest Compound Checklist

Safe vs. Sketchy Compounded GLP-1: The 14 Questions to Ask Before You Inject Anything

Most compounded GLP-1 ads want you to stop asking questions. We want you to ask more of them.

If you're considering compounded semaglutide or tirzepatide, you've probably read the horror stories — the mystery vials, the gray-market sourcing, the "too good to be true" prices. That fear is reasonable. The answer isn't to give up on compounded medicine. It's to learn how to tell the careful operators from the careless ones.

This checklist gives you the exact questions to ask any provider before you trust them with your body. Each one comes with why it matters and what a green-flag answer sounds like versus a red flag. Print it. Bring it to your next consult. Use it on us, too.

One thing up front, because honesty is the whole point: Compounded medications are **not FDA-approved**. We'll explain exactly what that does and doesn't mean in the first section — because any provider who skips past that is already failing your first test.

Quick Start: If You Only Ask 3 Questions

Short on time? Start here. These three separate most careful pharmacies from most sketchy ones.

1. **"Is the pharmacy licensed in my state, and can I verify it on my state board's website?"** (Item 1)
2. **"Is every batch tested by an independent third-party lab, and will you show me the certificate of analysis?"** (Item 6)
3. **"Is a licensed clinician actually reviewing my health history, and can I reach a pharmacist with questions?"** (Items 9 and 11)

If a provider dodges any of these three, stop. Everything else on this list matters, but these three are the fastest way to spot trouble.

Category 1: The Foundation (Read This First)

- ☐ **Do they openly tell you the medication is compounded and not FDA-approved?**

Why it matters: This is the single most important honesty test. Compounded drugs are made by a pharmacy for an individual patient. They are **not** FDA-approved, and that is true of all legitimate compounded medicine — not a secret to be buried in 6-point gray footnotes. What "not FDA-approved" means: the specific compounded product hasn't gone through the FDA's approval process for that formulation. What it doesn't mean: that compounding is illegal or unregulated. Compounding pharmacies are regulated by state boards of pharmacy and, for some, the FDA, and they compound active pharmaceutical ingredients such as semaglutide or tirzepatide. A compounded medication is still not the same as, and not equivalent to, the FDA-approved brand-name products. 🟢 Green flag: "Yes, this is compounded and not FDA-approved. Here's what that means for you." 🔴 Red flag: They call it "FDA-approved," imply it's "the same as Ozempic or Wegovy," or never use the word "compounded" at all.

- ☐ **Do they avoid promising you'll lose a specific amount of weight?** Why it matters:

Nobody can guarantee your results. GLP-1 medications work with your body's own appetite signals, and how that plays out is individual. Guaranteed numbers ("lose 20% — guaranteed!") are a regulatory red flag and, frankly, a sign someone is selling you a fantasy.

🟢 Green flag: "GLP-1 medications can support weight management as part of a care plan. Here's what to expect, including the parts that aren't fun." 🔴 Red flag: Guaranteed pounds, guaranteed percentages, "miracle," "magic," or before-and-after walls with no context.

Category 2: The Pharmacy

- ☐ **Is the pharmacy licensed in your state — and can you verify it yourself?** Why it

matters: A pharmacy shipping medication to you generally needs to be licensed in your state. This is verifiable. Most state boards of pharmacy have a public lookup tool where you can confirm a license is active and in good standing. 🟢 Green flag: They name the pharmacy and you can confirm an active license on your state board's site. 🔴 Red flag: They won't name the pharmacy, the name doesn't appear in any board database, or they get cagey when you ask "which pharmacy fills this?"

- ☐ **Is it a 503A or 503B pharmacy — and do they explain the difference?** Why it

matters: These are two real, distinct categories under federal law. A **503A** pharmacy compounds for an individual patient based on a specific prescription. A **503B** "outsourcing facility" can compound in larger batches and is registered with and inspected by the FDA under stricter manufacturing standards (cGMP). Neither makes a product "FDA-approved" — but a provider who can explain which one they use, and why, understands their own supply chain. 🟢 Green flag: They tell you plainly ("We work with 503A and 503B pharmacies, here's the difference") instead of waving it off. 🔴 Red flag: They don't know the terms, or treat your question like a nuisance.

- ☐ **Is the pharmacy based in the United States?** Why it matters: Many of the most worrying sourcing stories involve unregulated overseas suppliers or raw active ingredient (API) imported from facilities outside U.S. oversight. A U.S.-based, state-licensed pharmacy is operating inside a system you can actually check. ● Green flag: A named, licensed U.S. pharmacy. ● Red flag: Vague international shipping, "research chemical" language, or no clear country of origin.
 - ☐ **Where do they source the active ingredient, and is it from an FDA-registered facility?** Why it matters: The medicine is only as trustworthy as what goes into it. Reputable pharmacies source active pharmaceutical ingredients (API) from FDA-registered facilities and can speak to their sourcing. "Gray-market" API is exactly the risk you've read about. ● Green flag: They can describe where the API comes from and that it's from FDA-registered suppliers. ● Red flag: "We can't disclose that," evasiveness, or no answer at all.
-

Category 3: The Medicine

- ☐ **Is every batch tested by an independent, third-party lab?** Why it matters: Internal testing is one thing. Independent verification is another. Third-party lab testing checks that what's in the vial matches the label — the right ingredient, the right potency, and screening for contaminants. ● Green flag: "Yes, every batch is third-party tested." And they mean independent, not just in-house. ● Red flag: "We test internally" with no outside verification, or no testing answer at all.
- ☐ **Will they show you a Certificate of Analysis (COA)?** Why it matters: A COA is the document that proves the testing actually happened, with results for potency, purity, and contaminant screening. A pharmacy proud of its quality will share one. The honest move is to make this available, not hide it. ● Green flag: They provide a COA, or tell you exactly how to request one for your batch. ● Red flag: They've never heard of a COA, or refuse to produce one.
- ☐ **Are sterility and quality held to recognized standards (like USP)?** Why it matters: Injectable medications must be sterile. USP (United States Pharmacopeia) publishes the recognized standards for compounding sterile preparations (such as USP <797>). A pharmacy compounding injectables should be operating to these standards — that's how contamination risk is controlled. ● Green flag: They reference USP standards and sterile compounding practices without being prompted. ● Red flag: Blank stares on "sterility" or "USP," or products that arrive without proper sterile packaging.
- ☐ **Is the medication shipped and stored correctly (cold chain when required)?** Why it matters: Some of these medications need refrigeration. How it's packed, shipped, and how long it sat on a porch all affect whether the medicine is still good when it reaches you. ● Green flag: Clear storage instructions, appropriate cold-chain packaging, and guidance on what to do if a shipment is delayed. ● Red flag: No storage instructions, or medication that arrives warm with no explanation.

Category 4: The Prescriber

- ☐ **Is a licensed clinician actually reviewing your health history before prescribing?** Why it matters: This is real medicine, not a vending machine. A licensed clinician should evaluate your health history, current medications, and whether a GLP-1 is appropriate for you — and tell you honestly if it isn't. That clinical gate is a feature, not friction. 🟢 Green flag: A real intake, a real review, and a clinician who can say "this isn't right for you." 🔴 Red flag: Instant approval, no meaningful health questions, or "everyone qualifies."
 - ☐ **Can you reach a pharmacist or clinician with questions — after you start?** Why it matters: Side effects, dosing questions, and "is this normal?" moments don't keep business hours. Knowing a real person is reachable is part of safe care. 🟢 Green flag: A clear way to reach a pharmacist or care team when something comes up. 🔴 Red flag: No human contact, only a chatbot, or radio silence after they have your payment.
 - ☐ **Do they explain side effects and what to watch for — openly and up front?** Why it matters: Like any medication, GLP-1s have possible side effects (nausea and GI symptoms are common; there are also less common but more serious ones to know about). "Risk-free" and "no side effects" are claims regulators flag — and claims no honest provider makes. 🟢 Green flag: Side effects named clearly, before you buy, alongside what to do about them. 🔴 Red flag: "Risk-free," "completely safe," or side effects buried where you'll never look.
-

Category 5: The Fine Print

- ☐ **Is the total cost, billing cadence, and cancellation policy crystal clear before you pay?** Why it matters: You should know exactly what you're paying, how often, what happens as your dose changes, and how to cancel — before you sign up, not after. Surprise renewals and buried subscription terms are both a trust problem and a regulatory one. 🟢 Green flag: Transparent pricing, clear billing cadence, and an obvious, no-runaround way to cancel. 🔴 Red flag: Prices that appear only at checkout, fake countdown timers, "only 3 spots left," or a cancellation process designed to wear you down.
-

What "Good" Looks Like, All Together

A provider worth trusting will say the uncomfortable things first: *Yes, it's compounded. No, it's not FDA-approved. Here's the licensed pharmacy that makes it, here's how every batch is tested, here's the clinician reviewing your history, and here's exactly what you'll pay.*

That's not a sales pitch. That's just what honest care sounds like.

If you can ask these 14 questions and get straight, verifiable answers, you've found a provider who respects you enough to tell you the truth. If you can't, you've saved yourself from the exact thing you were afraid of.

This checklist is for education only. It is not medical or legal advice, and it isn't a substitute for talking with a licensed clinician or pharmacist about your specific situation. Compounded medications are not FDA-approved. Whether any medication — compounded or otherwise — is right for you is a clinical decision that requires evaluation by a qualified clinician. Verify any pharmacy's licensure through your state board of pharmacy. Always read the storage, dosing, and safety information that comes with your medication.